stand-off between Mody and Palkhivala; the latter was determined to stop Mody.

Meanwhile, Mody had left for England. While abroad, he said he had received a telephone call from the ailing Moolgaokar asking to meet him on his return. According to Mody, in the meeting, he was requested by Moolgaokar as well to take over the automobile giant, to which he gave his consent. After this meeting, Mody left for Calcutta en route to Jamshedpur.

In Calcutta, something was brewing. On 26 March 1988, a newspaper carried an article titled ‘Mody to be Chairman of Rs 3,000-cr. Empire’. This seemingly innocuously titled report, however, ended up damaging the prospects of the TISCO chairman.

The article showed the ailing TELCO chairman in poor light by saying that Mody, the ‘man with the Midas touch’, would be able to ‘turn around the fortunes of a troubled company’. The imputation was unmistakable—TELCO was being mismanaged by Moolgaokar. The article recalled Palkhivala’s assurance to the shareholders, when he had presided over the previous AGM, that the sagging financial prospects of the company would improve in the next year and commented that this would become a reality after Mody took over.

The report caused a storm in Bombay House. Its author, Aditi Roy Ghatak, had chanced upon a copy of a draft ‘Thank You’ letter to be sent as soon as Mody’s appointment as chairman, TELCO, became official. The letter got her curious. Pretending she was already aware of the appointment, she spoke to some of the staff members who raved about how their ‘boss’ would soon be declared the ‘badshah’ or emperor of Jamshedpur. They waxed eloquent on how Mody would be the saviour of TELCO, which was in the doldrums under the ‘tottering’ Moolgaokar.

Moolgaokar felt insulted by the article. He refused to step down in favour of Mody and vowed to continue in the saddle. Mody was unperturbed, though he claimed in an interview to a magazine some five years later that he had told Ratan: ‘Please tell him [Moolgaokar] that I had nothing to with the piece. It is the last thing that I would ever connive at.’ Mody evidently expected tempers to cool and did not imagine that Moolgaokar would stonewall his ambitions. But when he heard that Moolgaokar had refused to step down in his favour, he backtracked.

Within four days of the publication of the news item, he held a press conference where he denied having commented on TELCO’s financial